THE DATA PROFESSIONAL'S POWER TOOLKIT

Free tools to supercharge your workflow

POWERTOYS

VS CODE

EXCALIDRAW

OBSIDIAN

Jason Romans | DataTune Nashville | 2026

Jason Romans

Cloud Data & Integration Developer

The DAX Shepherd

Microsoft® MVP Most Valuable Professional

@sql_jar

jason-r-sql-jar

https://thedaxshepherd.com/

📍 Nashville, TN, USA

🛠️ Began Career as a SQL Server DBA

➡️ Transitioned to Microsoft BI Stack

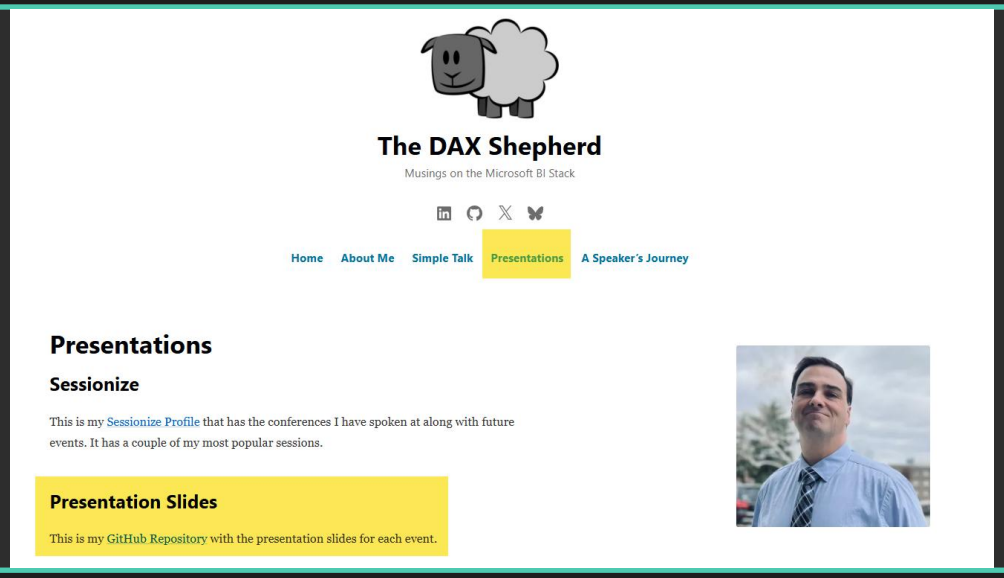
📦 Data Engineering to Data Modeling

DOWNLOAD THIS PRESENTATION

All slides, resources, and demo files available:

The DAX Shepherd

thedaxshepherd.com/presentations



Thanks to our 2026 Sponsors

Standing on the Shoulders of Giants

Grateful for the people who share their knowledge, encourage us, answer questions, and help the rest of us learn faster.

YOU ARE HERE

Intro — Obsidian — Excalidraw — VS Code — PowerToys — Wrap-Up

1. Intro

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2. Obsidian

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3. Excalidraw

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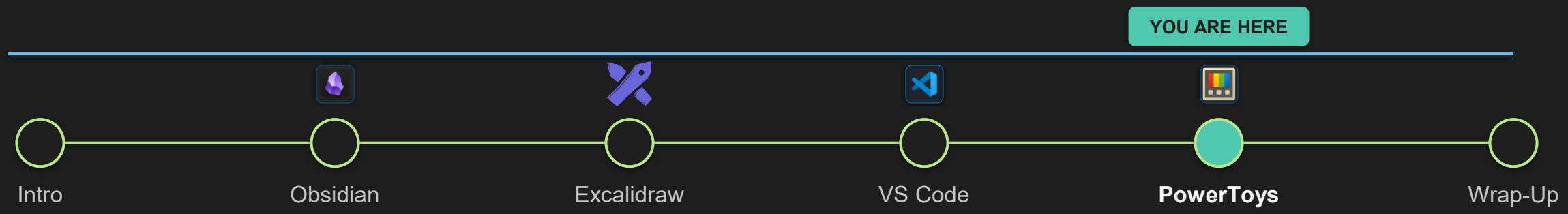
4. VS Code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5. Powertoys

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Intro — Obsidian — Excalidraw — VS Code — PowerToys — **Wrap-Up**

6. Wrap-Up

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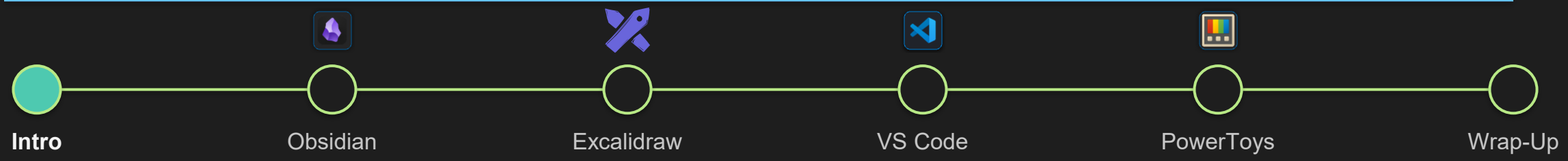

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All Four Tools Are Free

Obsidian — Free

- *optional: Sync $4/mo, Publish $8/mo*

Excalidraw — Free

- *optional: Excalidraw+ $7/mo for cloud & collab*

VS Code — Free

PowerToys — Free

The optional paid tiers exist. You don't need them to get full value.

Bring Your Own Installer

Tool	winget	choco	brew
Obsidian	Obsidian.Obsidian	obsidian	obsidian
Excalidraw	web app — no install	web app	web app
VS Code	Microsoft.VisualStudioCode	vscode	visual-studio-code
PowerToys	Microsoft.PowerToys	powertoys	*Windows only*

Already have a package manager? You're one command away.
VS Code also has a web version

🐘 Yes, We Need to Talk About AI

Tool	AI Superpower	How
Obsidian	**Copilot plugin**	Copilot plugin + local LLM support
Excalidraw	**AI diagram generation**	Generate diagrams from text descriptions
VS Code	**GitHub Copilot**	Copilot + Copilot Chat built right in
PowerToys	**Advanced Paste**	AI-powered clipboard transforms – local or cloud model

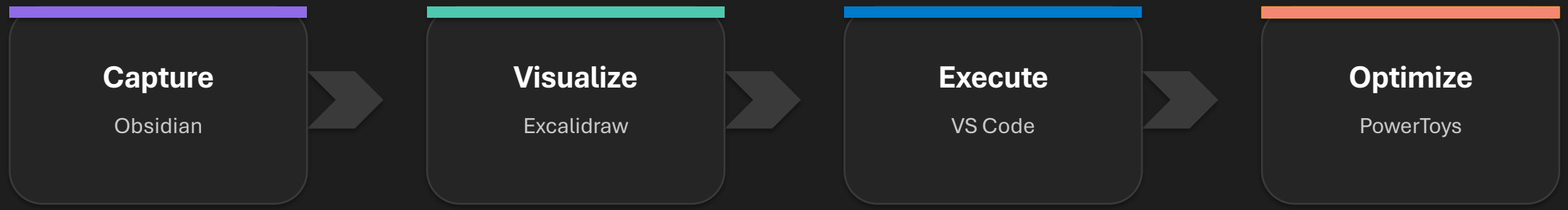
The tools were great before AI. They're better with it.

Every Tool is Extensible

Tool	Extension Model	Example
Obsidian	**Plugins**	Dataview, Calendar, Excalidraw
Excalidraw	**Libraries**	Pre-built data & architecture icon sets
VS Code	**Extensions**	Rainbow CSV, Jupyter, Python, Excalidraw
PowerToys	**Modules**	Enable only what you need

Start with the defaults. Extend to fit your workflow

The workflow



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OBSIDIAN

Capture notes, links, and ideas in one flexible knowledge base.

https://obsidian.md/

The Cult of Personality (aka Note-Taking Camps)

- Beware the trap: spending more time **choosing** than **using**
- Your notes should serve *your work*, not become the work

If you have a system that works — **keep using it.**

Why Obsidian?

- Your Second Brain for Technical Knowledge

Plain-text files you actually own — no vendor lock-in, open with any editor forever

Bidirectional links build a knowledge graph — see how ideas connect across your whole vault

Dataview turns your notes into a queryable database — filter and aggregate frontmatter like a spreadsheet

Conference Tracker

CFP_Dashboard

CFP Dashboard

> Last updated: March 04, 2026

🚨 Urgent - Closing Soon (Next 2 Weeks)

Conference (2)	Deadline	Time Left	Location	Intent
The_Cloud_AI_Summit_2026	March 10, 2026	🔥 6 days	St. Charles, Missouri	skip
Scenic_City_Summit_2026	March 15, 2026	1 week, 4 days	Chattanooga, Tennessee	submit

📅 Open CFPs (Next 30 Days)

Conference (4)	Deadline	Event Date	Location	Intent
LexTalk_Tech_Spring_2026	March 20, 2026	April 01, 2026	Lexington, Kentucky	undecided
Day_of_Data_Albany_2026	March 31, 2026	August 08, 2026	Albany, New York	undecided
Power_BI_Days_DC_2026	March 31, 2026	June 11, 2026	Arlington, Virginia	submit
Community_Summit_North_America_2026	March 31, 2026	October 11, 2026	Nashville, TN	submit

🎯 All Open CFPs (Future)

Obsidian — Demo

Let’s walk the vault.

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EXCALIDRAW

Visualize systems and workflows quickly without presentation friction.

https://excalidraw.com/

Why Excalidraw?

Diagrams at the speed of thought

— no UI friction, just sketch and ship

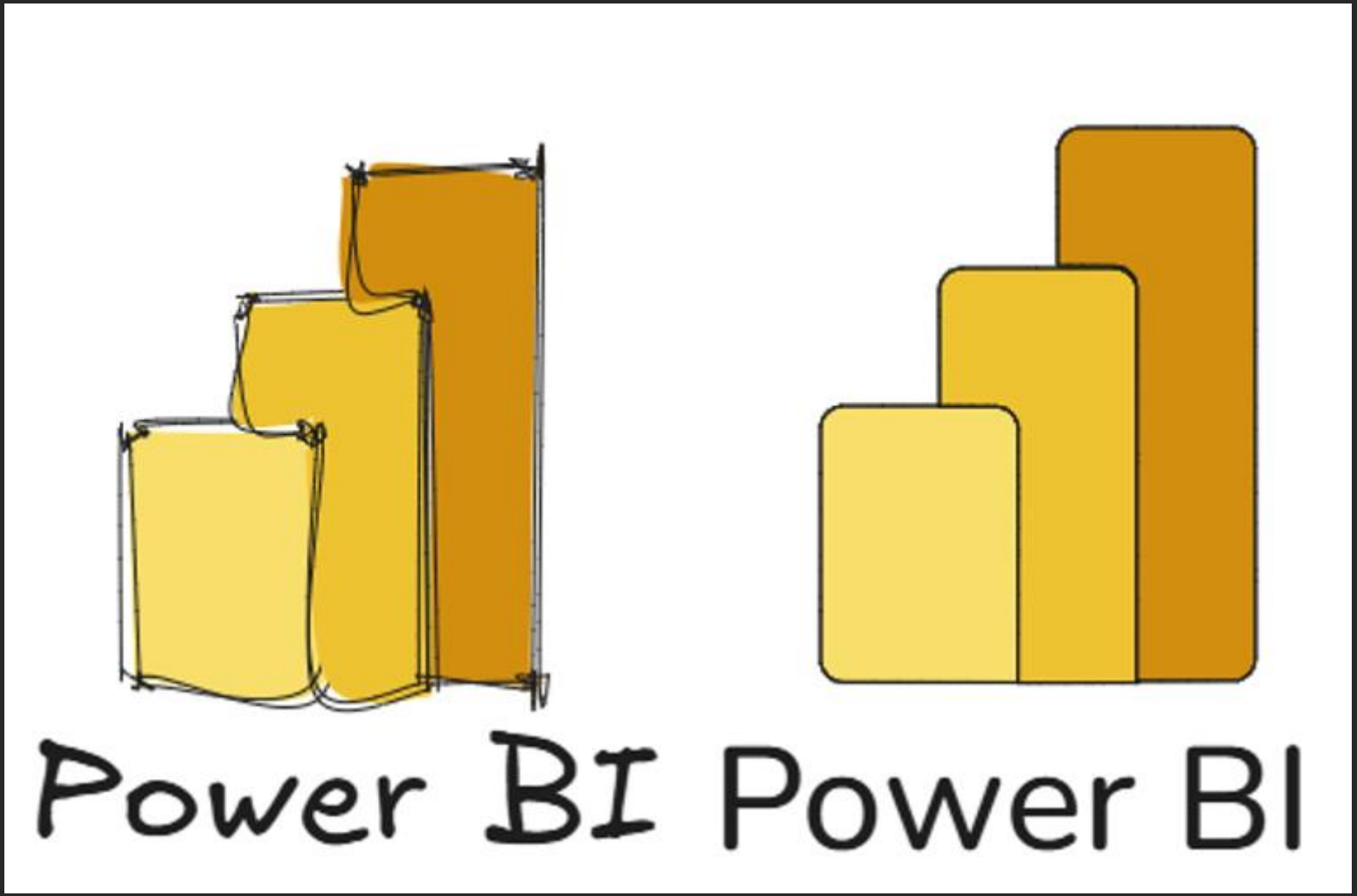
One-click icon libraries for any stack

— AWS, Azure, flowcharts, and more

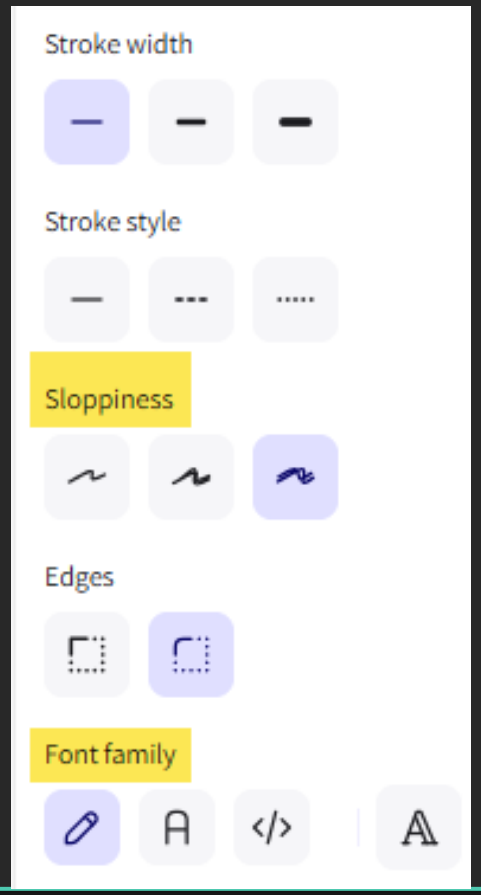
Embeds directly inside Obsidian

— diagrams live right beside your notes

Hand Drawn



Shape Properties



Quirk: Can’t set sloppiness as a default
Workaround: Draw shapes, then **Ctrl+A** → adjust all at once

Excalidraw — Demo

Let’s sketch something out.

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VS CODE (Visual Studio Code)

Execute edits and automation in the editor many data pros already use.

https://code.visualstudio.com/

Why VS Code?

Free, cross-platform, 50,000+ extensions

— runs on Windows, Mac, and Linux

Built for data work out of the box

— Jupyter notebooks, Rainbow CSV, Python, and SQL all-in-one

GitHub Copilot as your AI pair programmer

— context-aware completions for code and text

VS Code — Demo

Let’s pop open the editor.

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POWERTOYS

Optimize everyday Windows workflows with fast keyboard-driven utilities.

https://github.com/microsoft/PowerToys

Why PowerToys?

Command Palette: PowerToys Run, upgraded to V2

— same Alt+Space reflex, faster and more extensible

FancyZones: custom window grid layouts

— multi-monitor productivity without the frustration

Advanced Paste transforms your clipboard

— strip formatting, convert to Markdown or JSON

Try One Thing

You don’t need to use all 20+ utilities.

Find the one that solves your most annoying daily problem.

Open PowerToys → pick it from the left menu → enable it.

For many of us it started with ZoomIt

POWERTOYS

All PowerToys utilities

Launchers & quick actions

Advanced Paste
Paste clipboard into other formats — AI transforms available.

Command Not Found
Suggest WinGet packages for failed commands.

Command Palette
Launch commands, apps, and tools quickly. DEMO

PowerToys Run
Fast launcher for apps, files, and plugins. (See Command Palette)

Quick Accent
Type accented characters without changing layout.

Screen Ruler
Measure pixels on screen with edge detection.

Text Extractor
Copy text from anywhere on screen using AI-powered OCR.

Windows & layout

Always On Top
Pin a window above the rest of the desktop.

Crop And Lock
Create a live cropped or thumbnail window.

FancyZones
Snap windows into custom layouts fast. DEMO

Peek
Preview file content without opening apps.

Shortcut Guide
Show available Windows shortcuts in context.

Workspaces
Launch saved app sets into arranged positions.

Light Switch
Auto-switch between light and dark themes.

POWERTOYS

All PowerToys utilities

Files & content

Color Picker
Grab color values from any pixel.
DEMO

File Explorer add-ons
Preview more file types inside Explorer.

File Locksmith
See which process is locking a file.

Hosts File Editor
Edit hosts entries with a safer UI.

Image Resizer
Resize images from the Explorer menu.

New+
Create files and folders from templates.

PowerRename
Bulk rename with search, replace, and regex.

System & input

Awake
Keep the PC awake without changing settings.

Environment Variables
Manage environment variable profiles.

Keyboard Manager
Remap keys and create custom shortcuts.

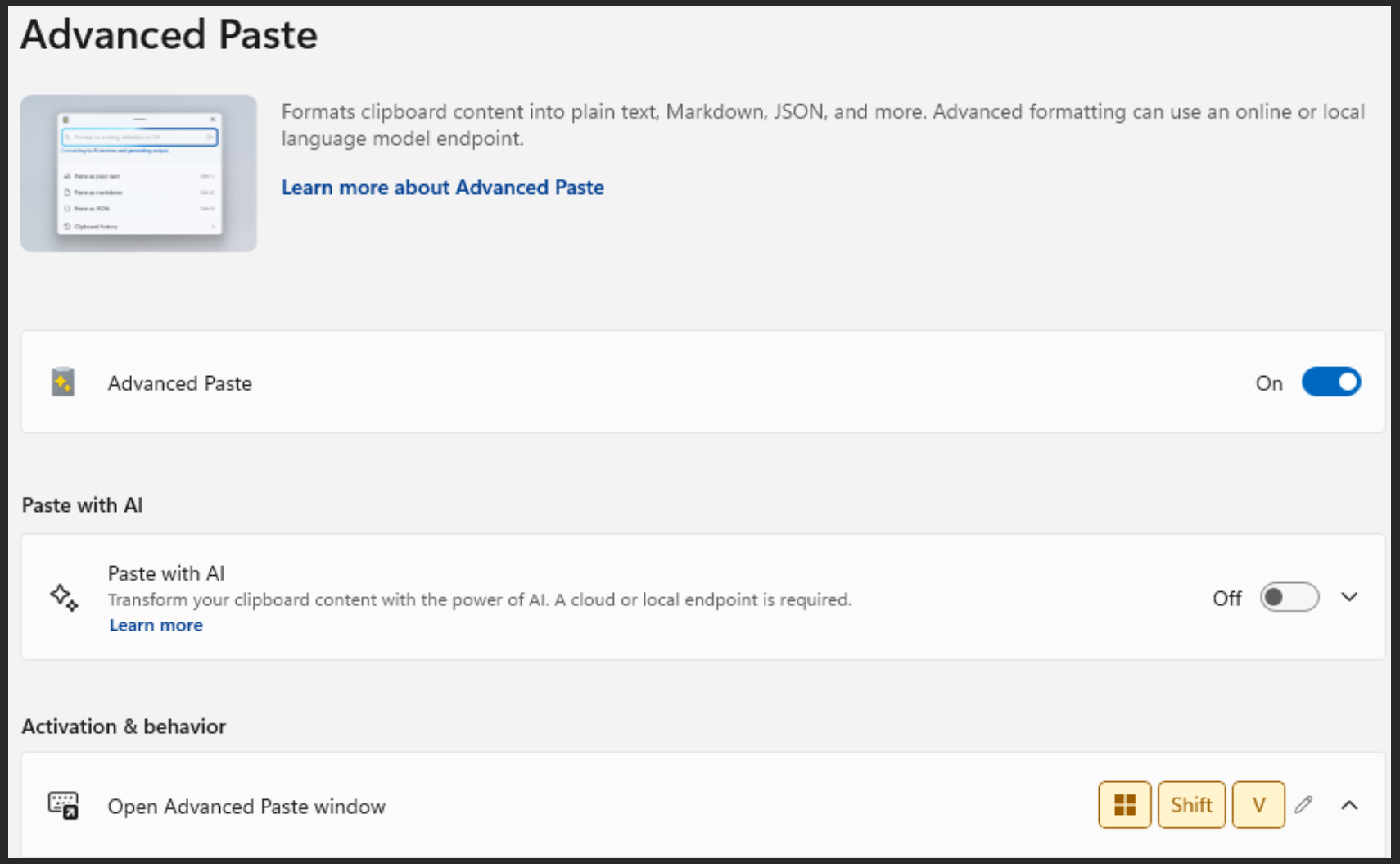
Mouse utilities
Find, highlight, or crosshair your cursor.

Mouse Without Borders
Use one keyboard and mouse across PCs.

Registry Preview
Preview and edit .reg files visually.

ZoomIt
Zoom, annotate, and record during demos.
DEMO

Options


Advanced Paste
Formats clipboard content into plain text, Markdown, JSON, and more. Advanced formatting can use an online or local language model endpoint.
Learn more about Advanced Paste
Advanced Paste
On
Paste with AI
Paste with AI
Transform your clipboard content with the power of AI. A cloud or local endpoint is required.
Learn more
Off
Activation & behavior
Open Advanced Paste window
Shift
V

PowerToys — Demo

Let’s supercharge Windows.

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Time to Commit These Changes

- Removing friction between you and your best work is what separates good data professionals from great ones.
- Start with one today, build a habit this week, and share it with your team. Free. Battle-tested. No vendor pitches. Just honest recommendations.

Work Smarter, Not Harder

Four free tools. Endless possibilities.

Obsidian — your second brain for notes and documentation
Excalidraw — sketch architecture and ideas instantly
PowerToys — take back control of your Windows workflow
VS Code — your universal data workbench

Resources

Obsidian	https://obsidian.md
Excalidraw	https://excalidraw.com
VS Code	https://code.visualstudio.com
PowerToys	https://github.com/microsoft/PowerToys

Go Deeper

Tool	Documentation	Learn More
Obsidian	help.obsidian.md	"Linking Your Thinking" — Nick Milo on YouTube *How to Take Smart Notes in Obsidian* — Josh Duffney
Excalidraw	docs.excalidraw.com	Zsolt Viczián's YouTube channel
VS Code	code.visualstudio.com/docs	Official VS Code YouTube channel
PowerToys	learn.microsoft.com/windows/powertoys	github.com/microsoft/PowerToys

Each tool has a community worth joining — start with the official docs.

THANK YOU

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Contact Information

Session Evaluation

The Data Professional's Power Toolkit: Free Tools to Supercharge Your Workflow